

Session 27: Narrative Analogy: Sarai and Genesis 3

Key Takeaways

- The story of Abram and Sarai in Genesis 12:10-20 is set on analogy to Genesis 3 through the use of repeated words.
- The story is an example of one of the main themes of the Bible—the complex and tragic human condition as people give into temptation over and over again. This temptation pattern is marked by repeated words such as “see,” “take,” “desire,” and “good in their eyes.”
- The story in Genesis 12:10-20 is an example of a dynamic analogy. This means characters move dynamically in and out of previously established character slots from stories to which the author is hyperlinking. For example, in a story hyperlinking to Genesis 3, a character can play the role of the snake and also be an inversion of the snake because their deception brings life instead of death.

Genesis 12:10-20 Recalls Genesis 3

Introduction: Avram Goes to Egypt Because of a Famine

- a 10 Now there was a **famine in the land** ;
b and Avram went down to Egypt to sojourn there,
a' for the **famine** was severe **in the land** .

Avram Nears Egypt + Avram's Speech to Sarai

- 11 And it came about when he came near to entering Egypt,
and he said to Sarai his wife,
“See now, I know that you are **a woman beautiful of sight** ;
12 and **when the Egyptians see you** , **they will say** , ‘ **This is his wife** ’ ;
and they will kill me, but they will let you live.
13 Please **say that you are my sister** so that **there will be good to me on account of you** ,
and that I may live on account of you.”

Egyptians See Sarai and Pharaoh Takes Her

- 14 And it came about when Avram came into Egypt,
and **the Egyptians saw that the woman was very beautiful** .
15 And Pharaoh's officials **saw her** and praised her to Pharaoh;
and the woman was **taken** into Pharaoh's house.

¹⁶ And **he did good to Avram on account of her** ;

and there was for him sheep and oxen and donkeys and male and female servants and female donkeys and camels.

Plagues on Pharaoh + Pharaoh's Speech to Avram

¹⁷ And Yahweh plagued Pharaoh and his house with great plagues on account of Sarai, **Avram's wife** .

¹⁸ And Pharaoh called Avram and he said,

"What is this you have done to me? **Why did you not tell me that she was your wife?**

¹⁹ **Why did you say** , ' **She is my sister** , ' so that I took her for **my wife** ?

Now then, here is **your wife** , take her and go."

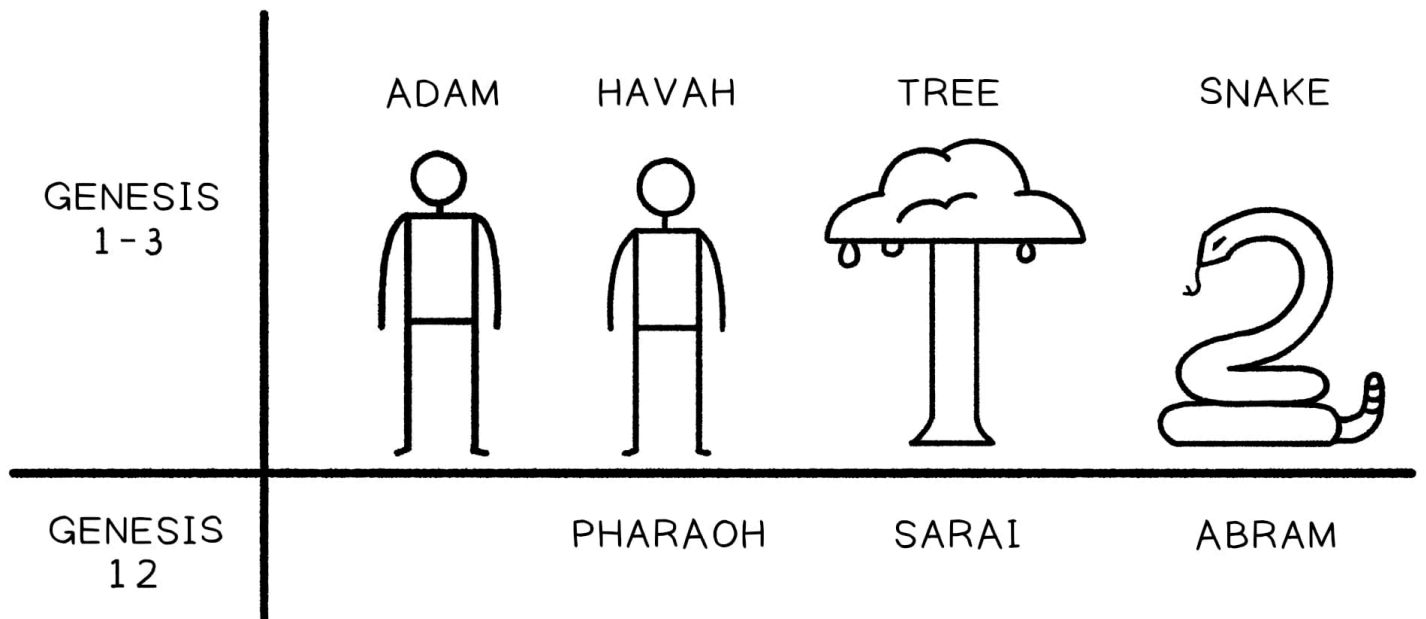
Conclusion: Avram Sent Away From Egypt by Pharaoh

²⁰ And Pharaoh commanded his men concerning him;
and they sent him away, with his wife and all that belonged to him.

Genesis 12:10-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Key vocabulary links Genesis 12 back to Genesis 3 and sets the characters of each story on narrative analogy to one another. This analogy is not fixed. Rather, it is dynamic, allowing the biblical authors to recall earlier stories and shift the associations with the characters as they play out the different archetypal roles.

DYNAMIC ANALOGY



Dynamic Analogy. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

How does the Genesis 12:10-20 text relate to the previous pattern established in Genesis 3 of humanity choosing what is good apart from God?